

On Pender county's economy

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Pender County, one of the three counties that make up the Wilmington metropolitan area, receives less attention than New Hanover and Brunswick. It has, however, changed considerably over the last two decades, both in terms of population and economic structure.

From a population perspective, Table 1 and Figure 1 show that domestic migration is the primary source of population change. Domestic migration was positive every year from 2010 to 2024 and accelerated sharply after the pandemic, reaching 2,604 in 2021, 2,570 in 2022, and 2,502 in 2023. Natural increase (difference between births and deaths) was positive but small from 2010 to 2019 and has been negative since. These values indicate that domestic migration has been the main contributor to population change, with natural increase playing a much smaller role and international migration remaining modest though rising toward the end of the period.

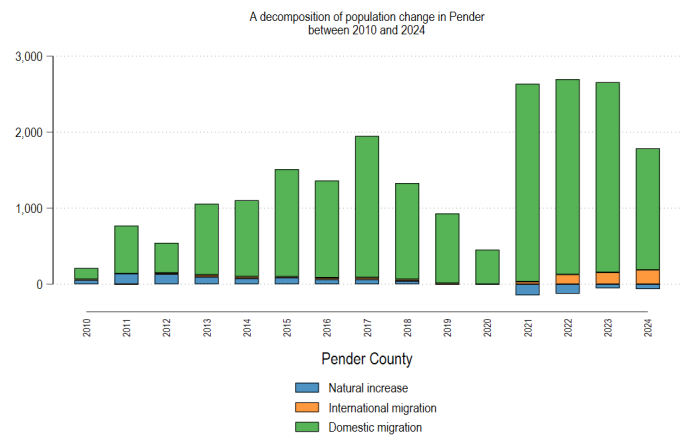


Figure 1: A decomposition of population change between 2010 and 2024 in Pender county

Table 1: Population change in Pender county

	Nat. increase	Inter. migration	Domestic migration
2010	54	10	147
2011	139	-7	631
2012	132	15	396
2013	96	26	936
2014	75	24	1005
2015	87	10	1416
2016	63	22	1278
2017	63	25	1861
2018	42	22	1266
2019	-3	12	918
2020	-3	0	454
2021	-146	33	2604
2022	-126	127	2570
2023	-54	155	2502
2024	-65	188	1599

In terms of age distribution, Table 2 and Figure 2 show

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that Pender County has a relatively balanced population across several major life stages rather than being dominated by any single group. The working-age population is sizable, and many of the near-retirement cohorts are large as well. For example, there are more than 4,600 residents ages 60 to 64 and more than 3,500 ages 65 to 69. The 70 to 74 group is similarly large, with over 4,000 residents combined. These patterns reflect a county with a meaningful number of older adults but not one that is disproportionately elderly.

Younger households are also well represented. School-age children make up a substantial portion of the population, with more than 5,000 children ages 5 to 9 and nearly 4,000 ages 10 to 14. The under-5 and 15 to 19 cohorts are also sizable. These figures point to a community with a significant share of families and continued demand for education-related services.

At the older end of the age spectrum, the population is smaller but still meaningful. Roughly 1,500 residents are between 80 and 84, and close to 800 are

85 or older. While smaller than the working-age and early-retirement groups, these numbers indicate a growing older-adult population that will continue to shape service and healthcare needs over time.

Across many age groups, women slightly outnumber men, with the gap widening at older ages, a pattern typical of most communities. The differences are modest in the working-age cohorts but become more pronounced beginning around age 60 and continuing into the 70s and 80s. These patterns reflect differences in longevity and mirror broader demographic trends across the region and state.

Table 2: Population by Age Group and Sex

Age Group	Males	Females
Under 5	2,135	1,319
5–9	2,767	2,252
10–14	2,015	1,978
15–19	2,770	1,762
20–24	1,848	1,948
25–29	1,912	2,162
30–34	2,416	1,680
35–39	2,222	1,782
40–44	2,039	2,870
45–49	2,373	1,748
50–54	2,304	2,901
55–59	2,688	2,851
60–64	2,222	2,462
65–69	2,159	1,434
70–74	1,685	2,514
75–79	1,310	1,222
80–84	613	927
85+	293	494

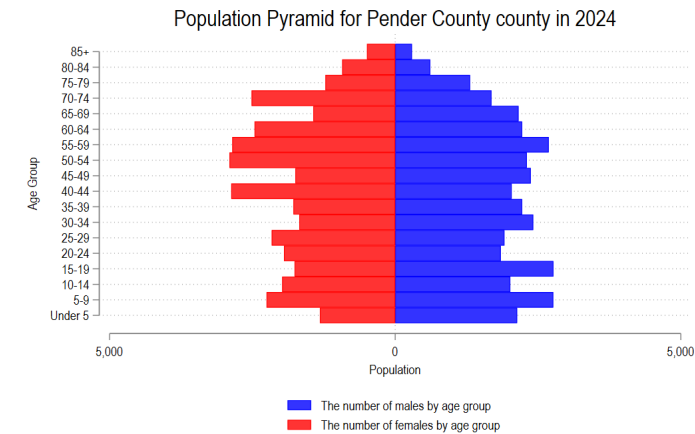


Figure 2: Age distribution in Pender County in 2024

What about Pender county’s economy?

We now turn to Pender County’s economy by focusing on establishments, employment, and wages. Figure 3 shows the number of establishments by sector in 2000 for Pender, New Hanover, and Brunswick counties. Pender had fewer establishments than the other counties across all sectors. Trade/transportation and utilities (186), construction (183), and professional and business services (120) were the only sectors with more than 100 establishments. Leisure and hospitality had only 77 establishments, about one-third of Brunswick’s total and roughly 13% of New Hanover’s.

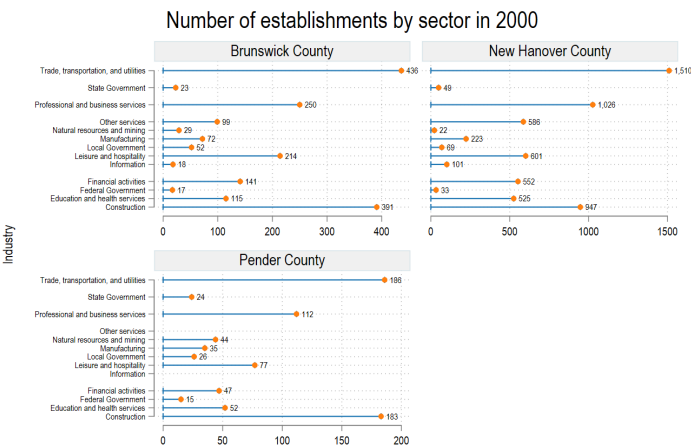


Figure 3: Number of establishments by sector for Pender, New Hanover, and Brunswick in 2000

Figure 4 shows the evolution of the number establishments between 2000 and 2024 in Pender County. The data show substantial growth and diversification. Establishments in the Financial activities increased from 47 to nearly 200 establishments, Healthcare grew from 52 to 195, and Professional and Business Services grew from a only 112 establishment to 437.

Figures 5 and 6 show employment in the three counties in 2000, and Pender’s sectoral employment changes between 2000 and 2004, respectively. In 2000, the three largest sectors in Pender County were local government (1,663), transportation (1,528), and manufacturing (1,136). No other sector had more than 1,000 employees. By 2024, six sectors exceeded 1,000 employees. Manufacturing now plays a smaller role, while Healthcare, Leisure and hospitality, and Professional and business services have all grown significantly.

Wages tell a similar story. Figure 7 shows that in 2000, most sectors had average weekly wages below \$500, with state, federal, and local government paying the most. By 2024, (Figure 8), wages rose across every major sector.

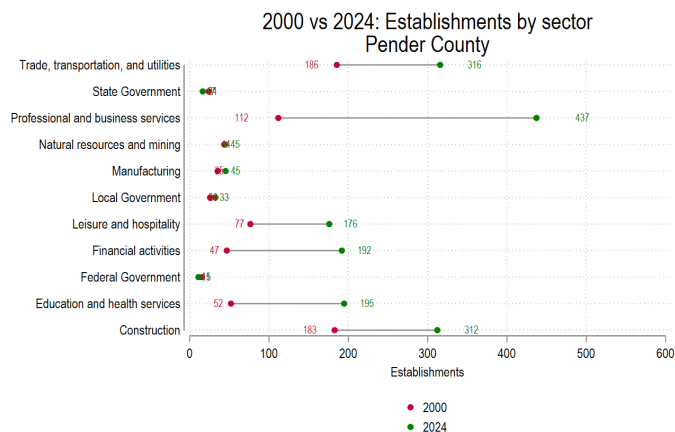


Figure 4: Number of establishments by sector in Pender County: 2000 vs. 2024

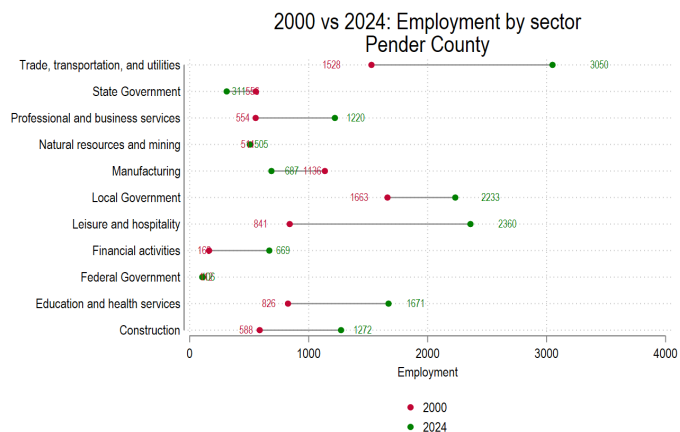


Figure 6: Employment by sector in 2000 and 2024 for Pender County

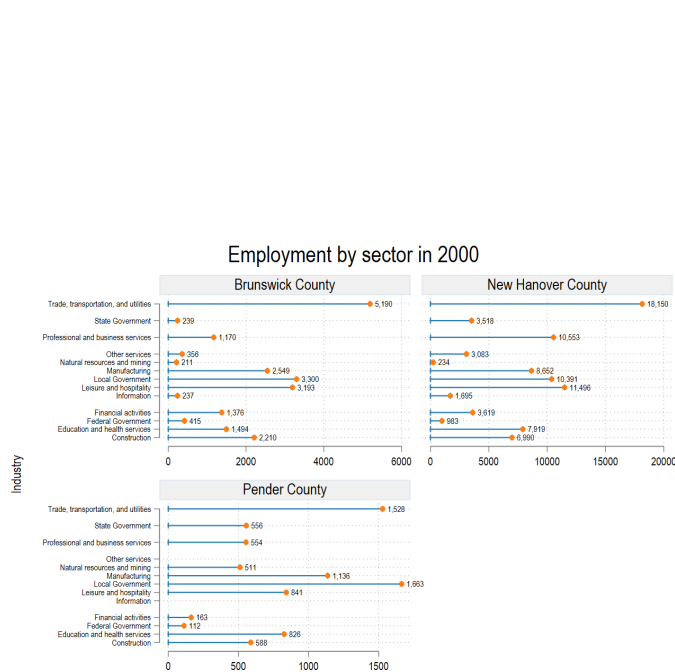


Figure 5: Employment by sector in 2000 for Pender, New Hanover, and Brunswick

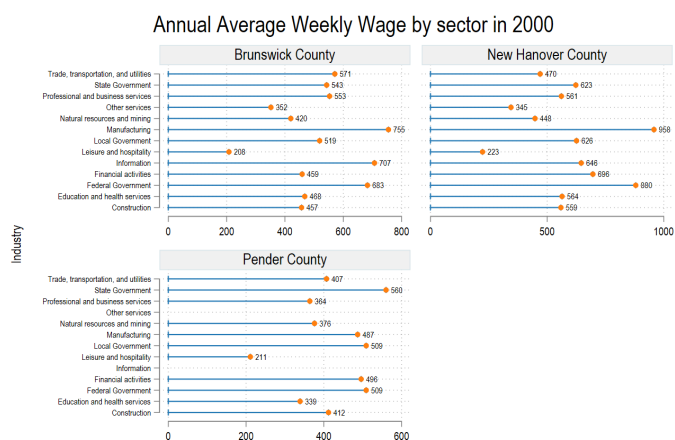


Figure 7: Average weekly wages by sector in New Hanover, Pender, and Brunswick counties
Note: Slight differences in averages exist due to methodological differences with Figure 8.

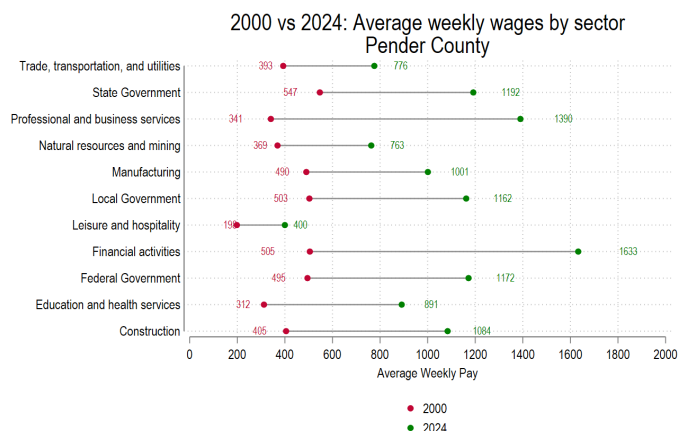


Figure 8: Average weekly wages in Pender County for 2000 and 2024

Increases were especially strong in Financial activities and in Professional and Business Services. Six sectors now have average weekly wages above \$1,000, reflecting a more competitive labor market and broader economic change.

Why does any of this matter?

Taken together, the demographic and economic trends show that Pender County has experienced substantial transformation over the last two decades. Population growth has been driven almost entirely by domestic migration, while natural increase has faded and the age structure now reflects large working-age and near-retirement cohorts. Economically, the county has expanded and diversified, with more establishments, a shift in employment toward service-oriented industries, and broad wage gains across sectors. These developments suggest that Pender is becoming more economically varied and increasingly tied to the wider regional growth dynamics. Understanding these changes is essential for planning infrastructure, workforce development, and long-range public investments as the county continues to adapt to new population pressures and a changing economic landscape.